

jewel in THE ROUGH

✱ **Anita Ahuja, 48**

Project An NGO that creates accessories by recycling waste material

Can-do Icon Mahatma Gandhi. A simple khadi-clad man who freed a whole nation, while embracing the most underprivileged.

In Delhi, there are more than 1 lakh rag-pickers, of whom 40,000 are women



question was how to groom people who had neither played with toys nor handled a pair of scissors ever in their life." She was quick to realise the first step was to teach colours to a community that had no common language nor a common culture as they were illegal immigrants from various countries.

Ahuja laughs as she describes how she came up with an ingenious way to teach them the palette. "I realised the only thing that was common to everyone was Bollywood." So, befittingly the darkest of blacks was Shah Rukh Khan, the purest of whites Aishwarya Rai Bachchan and

the hottest of pinks was always Kareena Kapoor. As one walks through the workstation in the Madanpur Khadar slum area, where 100-odd people are associated with Conserve, one can see the pictures of Shah Rukh Khan in black stuck in places with black polythene bags stapled nearby to signal to the pickers what they have to collect for the next order. The women seem happy to see Ahuja as she enters to monitor the work.

Conserve now exports bags, accessories and footwear—all made of recycled materials. Ahuja laments the lack of interest in the

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As a person one has a responsibility to society and as an artist one can create. One can also design and create for the poor. That's what I choose to do.

ANITA AHUJA, Founder, Conserve

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community of rag-pickers. The Government hesitates to help them on grounds of their illegality in India, but she continues in her own little way as she delegates and organises work to three major slums around Delhi. "I feel I can provide something for those who live by the motto of *taazi kamaao, taazi khaao* (earn and consume instantly)," says Ahuja. She hopes the Government will be able to make a difference, "I realised after I helped open a school in the Madanpur slum that they want to educate their children." The school has about 200 children and is partly supported by Conserve.

Amongst the vivid colours of plastic and unfinished bags that lie around Ahuja at her office, she talks about her work. The women around her are washing and sanitising polythene bags. Some cut them carefully into shapes, while others are drying them in the fluttering breeze. The women take their work seriously. But there is still a hesitation that lurks in them and Ahuja wants to erase that. "Look, I didn't shy away from the camera, you all must learn to talk up and get over your diffidence," she tells them, encouraging them to reach out for the world. It's within their grasp. ■

